Shifting Left

Abi Harrison-Nye

What is it for?

Imagine baking a cake, pulling it out of the oven, and realising you forgot the sugar. It's much easier to just add the sugar at the beginning.

Shifting left means moving accessibility checks to the very beginning of the project (the left side), instead of waiting until the end to test it. Finding an accessibility bug during the design phase is incredibly cheap and fast to fix.

How to support it

- Designers can check colour contrast and plan out where keyboard focus will go before sending pictures to the developers
- Developers can plan out which Semantic HTML tags to use before writing any complex code
- Product Managers can make sure accessibility is listed as a requirement for the feature to be considered Done

This early planning saves a massive amount of time and money at the end.

Useful Links

Deque: Shift Left Accessibility Testing

Shift-left accessibility: Embedding inclusion early in agile projects